The little green book was going to travel with us, passed from hand to hand, throughout the tournament, and Hashim made his contribution after our first warm-up match against Sri Lanka in Christchurch. 'It went pretty well,' he wrote. 'Suffice to say, we chased down a decent total after bowling well. The days preceding the World Cup are a good time for the team to get the bonding in order, before the real responsibility begins.'

He passed the book on to Russell, who wrote about missing his sons, Kyle and Liam, and added: 'You guys have no idea how influential and important you are to so many kids back home.' The coach concluded by writing: 'The last thought I have before I go to bed is that everyone is fighting a battle in life ... whether it's from within, something at home, financial, emotional, esteem, anything. Everyone wants love. Let's try and make a difference in each other's life. That's quite deep for a fisherman, but we all just need some connection.'

Wayne Parnell was the next recipient of the book, and his contribution reflected on a defeat against New Zealand in our second warm-up match in Christchurch, when they scored 331 and reduced us to 62 for six before Vernon and JP made runs and helped us to 197. We were not fazed by the outcome and Wayne wrote: 'Bags have been packed and shipped to Hamilton and soon we will follow. Everyone is very excited about 15/2/15 because that is when we take the first steps to reaching the MCG and turning our dream into reality #proteafire.'

The format was unchanged from 2011, with 14 participating countries divided into two groups of seven and the top four from each round-robin group advancing to the quarterfinals, followed by the semifinals and the 2015 ICC Cricket World Cup final at the Melbourne Cricket Ground on Sunday, 29 March.

Our opening match, against Zimbabwe in Hamilton, was always going to be tricky and it became significantly more dangerous when we lost the toss and, sent in to bat on a difficult pitch at Seddon Park, found ourselves in trouble at 83 for four. The first pressure moment had arrived